



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MGN 702 (M) Amendment 2

Maritime autonomous surface ships of less than 2.5 metres in LOA

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Summary

This Marine Guidance Notice (MGN) explains a General Exemption which has been issued for Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships of <2.5 metres in length overall.

This General Exemption enables eligible vessels to operate without certification issued by the Maritime and Coastguard Agency (MCA), or its delegates.

This General Exemption does not exempt eligible vessels from all merchant shipping regulations or other maritime requirements.

For the General Exemption for the vessel to be valid all applicable conditions of this General Exemption are required to be met.

Failure to maintain compliance with the conditions set out in herein will invalidate any exemption and the vessel will be expected to fully comply with all the applicable regulations.

This General Exemption is effective from 05 August 2024.

1. Introduction

1.1 Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships (MASS) include every description of vessel or craft used in navigation that can for any part of its voyage, fully or in part navigate or operate autonomously or through remote operations.

1.2 Remotely Operated Unmanned Vessel (ROUV) means a vessel with no persons on board, that is operated from a location remote to the

vessel.

2. Background

2.1 To date, there have been two pathways to certification available for MASS:

2.1.1 MASS may undertake a case-by-case assessment through application of the MGN 664 process and, if successful, may be issued with a load-line exemption certificate; or

2.1.2 ROUVs of <24 metres in load-line length may be surveyed and issued with a Workboat Code Edition 3 certificate.

2.2 To provide specific support to the MiniMASS sector the Maritime and Coastguard Agency have issued a General Exemption for MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall, which ensures that eligible vessels have an available proportional pathway.

2.3 Owners or operators of MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall may alternatively still choose to follow either of the pathways set out in 2.1.

2.4 This General Exemption is effective from 05 August 2024.

3. General Exemption for MASS <2.5 metres in Length Overall

3.1 This General Exemption only applies to MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall which comply with all of the conditions set out within the General Exemption.

3.2 There may be other Regulations which apply to a specific vessel. The owner/operator of a vessel has a responsibility to identify which Regulations apply to a specific vessel and its intended operations.

3.3 The Maritime and Coastguard Agency has made the assumption that MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall will not carry EPIRBs.

If the owner/operator of a vessel to which this General Exemption applies chooses to carry EPIRBs they shall comply with The Merchant Shipping

(EPIRB Registration) Regulations 2000 (SI 2000/1850).

3.4 The Maritime and Coastguard Agency has made the assumption that MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall will not be designed or constructed to carry ballast water.

A MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall which is designed or constructed to carry ballast water shall comply with The Merchant Shipping (Control and Management of Ships' Ballast Water and Sediments) Regulations 2022 (SI 2022/737).

3.5 The Maritime and Coastguard Agency recommends that the operator of a MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall implements appropriate means to enhance the visibility and detectability of the vessel by other water users.

3.6 All MASS of <2.5 metres in length overall should consider fitting, where practicable, the most effective and appropriate radar reflector or radar target enhancer for their circumstances; and ensure those comply with international standards (see MGN 349, as amended).

3.7 The General Exemption will be reviewed alongside the Post-Implementation Review (PIR) of Workboat Code Edition 3.

3.8 The Maritime and Coastguard Agency retains the right to retract this General Exemption at any time.

4. Vessel Identification

4.1 When a vessel is declared against the General Exemption for Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships (MASS) of less than 2.5 metres in length overall for the first time, it will be assigned a unique identification number, in accordance with the standard format set out below.

4.2 An example unique identification number is:

M702000

which denotes that this is a vessel declared against the General Exemption for Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships (MASS) of less than 2.5 metres in length overall.

4.3 A vessel shall continue with the unique identification number assigned to it at initial declaration for the lifetime of the vessel.

4.4 The vessel shall have clearly displayed means of identification positioned on its exterior above the static waterline, and in a contrasting colour to the area of the vessel it is applied to. This shall enable other water users to:

- .1 identify the vessel; and
- .2 identify the vessel owner/operator; and
- .3 either provide contact details for the vessel owner/operator; or
- .4 provide means of identification which would enable water users to source contact details for the vessel owner/operator.

If a single means of identification is not able to meet the requirements of this provision, a vessel may instead use a combination of means of identification.

4.5 Examples of means of identification include, but are not limited to:

- .1 vessel's MCA-issued unique identification number;
- .2 vessel owner/operator's contact details;
- .3 vessel name;
- .4 company logo;
- .5 QR code.

4.6 Evidence of the chosen means of identification must be provided to codes@mcga.gov.uk.

5. Further Information

5.1 Further information relating to Workboat Code Edition 3 can be obtained from the links listed below:

5.1.1 Workboat Code Edition 3 can be accessed at:
<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-workboat-code-edition-3>
(<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-workboat-code-edition-3>).

5.1.2 The Merchant Shipping (Small Workboats and Pilot Boats) Regulations 2023 can be accessed at:

<https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2023/1216/contents/made>
(<https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2023/1216/contents/made>).

5.2 Further information relating to MGN 664 can be obtained from the link listed below:

5.2.1 MGN 664 (Amendment 1) Certification Process for Vessels using Innovative Technology <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-664-mf-amendment-1-certification-process-for-vessels-using-innovative-technology> (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-664-mf-amendment-1-certification-process-for-vessels-using-innovative-technology>)

More Information

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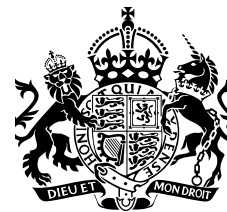
Email: codes@mcga.gov.uk

Website: www.gov.uk/mca (<https://www.gov.uk/mca>)



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